

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CANADA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

A practical guide for communities facing destructive development projects in Canada, grounded in Canadian law and documented campaigns

***A note on terms.** Important terms are shown in **bold** the first time they appear, and each is defined in parentheses right where you first meet it — no flipping to the back required.*

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Community action directly determines project outcomes in Canada. Projects that clear every economic and political hurdle still die when opposition is organized, documented, and — above all — when the constitutional rights of Indigenous peoples are not respected. The record of the last decade is unambiguous: the Northern Gateway pipeline, the \$15.7-billion Energy East pipeline, and the Teck Frontier oilsands mine were all abandoned after opposition made them legally and politically untenable, and the Trans Mountain expansion was quashed mid-stream by the Federal Court of Appeal.

But most communities don't know HOW to make opposition effective. They protest, then give up. They assume "the government will stop it" without building public pressure. They generate media coverage without a strategy. They organize people and then lose them to burnout after four months.

This guide shows what actually works — in the Canadian system.

If You're New to This — Don't Be Shy

Nobody is born knowing how an environmental assessment works. The communities in this guide weren't experts when the projects landed on them — they learned it, meeting by meeting, filing by filing, because the thing at stake was theirs. That is the only qualification this work requires.

So if this is your first fight: don't worry, and don't be shy. You are allowed to file comments, demand documents, call reporters, and pack a hearing. The participation windows exist for you, not for specialists. You will make mistakes; every winning campaign did. Start small — one conversation, one document request, one meeting — and let the guide carry you from there. You want it? Go and get it.

The Strategic Framework

Successful opposition campaigns follow the same basic pattern:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION
↓
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (proof of harm)
↓
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION BUILD (organized community)
↓
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (regulatory / court pressure)
↓
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (public visibility)

These operate SIMULTANEOUSLY (not sequentially)
Each step amplifies the others
Multi-tactic pressure compounds toward victory
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The strongest legal lever: running through all five steps is the single most powerful legal lever in the country — the constitutional duty to consult and accommodate Indigenous peoples (Step 4). Where a project affects Indigenous rights and that duty is not met, courts have quashed approvals outright. No community campaign in Canada should be planned without understanding it.

Critical Caveat: A Tilted System Can Make Opposition Harder (But Doesn't Make It Impossible)

Before you invest time, money, and emotional energy, understand this:

First, a definition. This guide calls it a **system tilted toward approval** (sometimes called *regulatory capture* or *institutional bias*). It does not mean anything illegal. It means the bodies that decide on a project lean toward approving it — because they depend on the industry's money or jobs, rely on the proponent's own information, or face strong political pressure to say yes.

In some Canadian development decisions, systemic bias exists — provincial budgets dependent on resource royalties, “free entry” mining systems that grant claims with no up-front consultation, assessments funded and written by the proponent, and courts that heavily favour well-resourced parties (and that issue injunctions against blockades).

When these factors are present, opposition becomes harder. It does not become impossible. It becomes more expensive, takes longer, and has a lower probability of stopping a project outright — but it still routinely wins delays, modifications, buffers, monitoring, and funded oversight.

This is covered in Section 9. Read it before committing resources.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS: WHO DECIDES, AND HOW

If you've never dealt with how projects get approved, read this section first. It explains, in plain terms, who holds power over a development in Canada, how a decision gets made, why the money so often points toward “yes,” and the handful of words you'll need. Every term is defined here on first use. The rest of the guide assumes you know this map.

The levels of government — and what each one controls

Canada divides power over land and development among several levels, and — uniquely — the rights of Indigenous peoples run through all of them. Which body decides depends on what is being built and where.

- **The municipality** (city, town, or regional district) — the most local tier, run by an elected **council**. It controls **zoning** (what may be built on a given piece of land), **rezoning**, official community plans, and local **development and building permits**. Most housing, commercial, and local land-use fights are decided here.
- **The province (or territory)** — the most powerful level for **land, resources, and the environment**. Provinces run their own **environmental assessment (EA)** processes and issue the permits that actually let work happen: **mining permits, water licences, forestry cutting permits, and air, waste, and discharge approvals**. Because Canada's provinces own most Crown (public) land and its resources, the province is usually the key decision-maker for mines, quarries, dams, forestry, and most energy projects. Each province has its own body (for example, British Columbia's Environmental Assessment Office, Ontario's Ministry of the Environment, Quebec's public-hearing body the BAPE, and Alberta's regulator the AER).
- **The federal (national) government** — steps in for defined matters. The **Impact Assessment Agency of Canada (IAAC)** (the federal agency that runs assessments of large designated projects) runs a federal assessment of large

“**designated projects**” (major mines, some pipelines, large infrastructure), with the final decision made by the federal Cabinet or a Minister. The **Canada Energy Regulator (CER)** (the federal regulator for pipelines and power lines that cross provincial or national borders) decides on pipelines and power lines that cross provincial or national borders. Federal laws also protect **fish and fish habitat, species at risk, and migratory birds**, which can bring a project under federal review.

- **Indigenous nations and governments** — are **rights-holders, not stakeholders**. Section 35 of Canada’s Constitution protects Aboriginal and treaty rights, and governments have a legal **duty to consult and accommodate** Indigenous peoples when a decision may affect those rights. This runs across municipal, provincial, and federal decisions, and it is often the single most powerful factor in a project’s fate (Step 4 explains it fully).

So which level decides your project? - A housing development, a shopping centre, a local land-use change → the **municipality**. - A mine, a quarry, a dam, a forestry cut, most energy projects → mainly the **province** (with a federal review if it’s a large “designated project”). - A pipeline or power line crossing a provincial or international border → the **federal CER**. - Anything affecting Indigenous rights or territory → engages the **duty to consult**, at whatever level the decision sits.

How a decision is actually made — the journey of an application

1. **Application** to the relevant body (municipal permit, provincial EA and permits, or a federal impact assessment) with supporting reports — including, for larger projects, an **environmental assessment / impact statement** prepared by the proponent (the company behind the project).
2. **Public comment periods** — federal and provincial processes have formal windows where anyone can file comments; municipalities hold public hearings on rezonings.
3. **Indigenous consultation** — where rights may be affected, the Crown must consult (and, where appropriate, accommodate) the affected nation.
4. **Assessment and decision** — officials assess the project against the law and the comments, and the decision-maker (a council, a Minister, a regulator, or Cabinet) approves, approves with conditions, or refuses.
5. **Legal challenge** — a decision that is *unlawful* can be taken to court by **judicial review** (asking a court to rule that a decision was unlawful), usually within a **short deadline** (Step 4).

The rulebook — the policies that decide the outcome

- **The Impact Assessment Act** (federal) — governs assessment of large “designated projects”; its decisions now turn on adverse effects within federal jurisdiction.
- **Provincial environmental-assessment laws** — each province’s own EA statute and permit regime; these govern most resource projects.
- **The Fisheries Act, the Species at Risk Act (SARA), and the Migratory Birds Convention Act** — federal laws that protect fish habitat, listed species, and birds, and can pull a project into federal review.
- **The Canadian Environmental Protection Act (CEPA)** — federal pollution law, amended in 2023 to recognise a right to a healthy environment.
- **Section 35 of the Constitution Act, 1982** — the source of the duty to consult Indigenous peoples.

Follow the money — why the system often leans toward “yes”

- **Municipalities** are funded mainly by **property taxes** and **development charges** (fees developers pay toward local infrastructure), so new development can mean more revenue and jobs — a built-in pull toward approval.
- **Provinces** collect **royalties** (a share of the value of extracted minerals, oil, gas, and timber) and depend on resource industries for jobs and revenue, which creates strong political pressure to approve mines, wells, and cuts.
- **Proponents** are usually well-resourced companies that pay for the consultants and lawyers who prepare and defend the project.

None of this makes a decision inevitable. It explains why decisions rarely tip your way on their own — it takes organised, evidenced pressure, and, where rights are engaged, the constitutional weight of the duty to consult.

The overseers — who watches the decision-makers

- **The courts** — the **Federal Court** and **Federal Court of Appeal** review federal decisions; each province’s **superior court** reviews provincial ones. Courts can **quash** (cancel) an unlawful decision.
- **The duty to consult** itself acts as a check: courts have overturned major approvals where the Crown failed to consult adequately.
- **Provincial ombudspersons and auditors** — investigate maladministration and spending.

The Clock — Every Deadline That Matters

The process runs on short, unforgiving windows, and one principle governs them all: **object early and comprehensively**. Arguments never placed in the participation record are far weaker later — points not raised in the public windows can be barred or discounted — so file everything, in every window, and keep every receipt. Confirm each figure below against the actual notice or with counsel the day it becomes relevant; notices set the live dates.

Stage	Your window	The trap
EA comment periods	Fixed windows in each federal/provincial phase — file in every one	Points never filed weaken every later challenge
Permit appeals	Often measured in days to weeks — the permit states it	The clock is in the fine print; read it the day it issues
Federal judicial review	Generally 30 days from the decision	Filing late is fatal to the claim
Injunction/stay motions	Immediately, before irreversibility	After the trees are down, the stay is moot
Access to Information (ATIP) / provincial FOI	30 days statutory response	Denials are appealable to the commissioners — appeal them
Compliance complaints	Any time — each violation, every time	Undocumented harms never happened

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES BY STEP & COMBINATION

These ranges describe the general effectiveness of each tactic drawn from documented opposition campaigns. They are patterns, not guarantees. In Canada, the single biggest variable that can push a campaign above these ranges is a well-founded Indigenous-rights / duty-to-consult challenge (Step 4).

Individual Step Success Rates

Step	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost (CAD)	What “Success” Means
Documentation Only	5-10%	3-4 months	\$6K	Project slowed, public awareness only
Opposition Only	15-20%	6-12 months	\$18K	Public pressure, minor modifications
Legal Only	20-30%	12-24 months	\$60K	Slow process, often loses on its own
Media Only	10-15%	3-6 months	\$7K	Public knows, but no action
Docs + Opposition	25-35%	12 months	\$24K	Slowed, some modifications
Docs + Legal	30-40%	12-18 months	\$66K	Stronger legal arguments, slower
Opposition + Legal	35-45%	12-18 months	\$78K	Political pressure strengthens the case
Opposition + Media	30-40%	9-12 months	\$25K	Visibility creates political pressure
All 5 Steps Combined	60-75%	12-24 months	\$78K	Approval modified/denied or project delayed

Key insight: All five steps together = 3-4x more effective than any single step.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Core Questions You Must Answer

Before you organize a single person, answer these precisely.

Question 1: What Exactly Will Be Destroyed?

Not: “Environmental damage” But: “The mine will disturb 2,300 hectares of caribou range and cross three fish-bearing streams, during calving season, in an area used for the exercise of treaty harvesting rights.”

Not: “Water contamination” But: “Pipeline construction 90 metres from the community water intake; the proponent’s own model shows sediment reaching the intake during freshet.”

Not: “Community harm” But: “The facility’s emissions increase fine particulate (PM2.5) by an estimated 4 µg/m³ over the nearest neighbourhood of 1,500 people.”

Why this matters: specific harms are easier to document, litigate, and organize around. Vague opposition dies; specific opposition survives.

Question 2: Who Has Decision-Making Power?

You cannot pressure an abstraction. In Canada a single project often has decision-makers at three levels — identify each one by name and role:

- **Federal — impact assessment.** For a “designated project,” the **Impact Assessment Agency of Canada (IAAC)** runs the assessment and the federal Cabinet or Minister makes the final decision, now turning on *adverse effects within federal jurisdiction* (post-June 2024 amendments). Registry: the Canadian Impact Assessment Registry (CIAR).
- **Federal — energy infrastructure.** For interprovincial/international pipelines and power lines, the **Canada Energy Regulator (CER)** and its Commission decide. Nuclear projects go to the Canadian Nuclear Safety Commission.
- **Provincial.** Each province runs its own environmental-assessment regime and issues most of the permits that let dirt actually move — water licences, mine permits, forestry cutting permits, air and waste approvals (e.g., BC’s Environmental Assessment Office, Ontario’s Ministry of the Environment, Quebec’s BAPE, Alberta’s AER).
- **Municipal.** Zoning, rezoning, official-plan amendments, development permits.

Write it down concretely: “The provincial Minister of Environment must issue the EA certificate. Public comment closes March 15. The First Nation in whose territory the project sits has asserted rights and has not consented.”

Question 3: What Specific Action Stops It?

Not: “Stop the project” But: “Refuse the EA certificate” — or, if a refusal is unrealistic, “impose binding conditions: a 500-metre stream buffer, a \$20M reclamation bond, and independent Indigenous-led monitoring.”

Not: “Protect the environment” But: “Send the impact statement back as inadequate on cumulative effects and species-at-risk” (a specific, winnable regulatory outcome).

Why this matters: you can demand something achievable. Vague demands are easy to ignore; specific demands create measurable pressure.

Question 4: When Is the Decision Final?

Timeline tells you how much time you have. Federal and provincial assessments run in defined phases with fixed public-comment windows; permits have appeal deadlines (often measured in days to weeks); judicial review of a federal decision generally must be filed within a short statutory window. Map every date: comment deadlines, hearing dates, the decision date, and the deadline to challenge it.

Question 5: Are There Documented Financial Interests or Systemic Pressures?

This is the tilted-system assessment question. Know it BEFORE you organize: - Does the province depend heavily on royalties/revenue from this sector? - Is the assessment funded and written by the proponent only? - Does the regulator approve nearly everything (a high approval rate)? - Is the mineral/tenure system “free entry” (claims granted with no up-front consultation)? - Are there undisclosed proponent-regulator contacts, or board members with industry ties?

Why this matters: if the decision-makers face strong revenue pressure or the process is proponent-controlled, opposition must overcome different barriers (Section 9). It doesn’t mean opposition can’t work — it means realistic expectations and, often, a focus on modifications and the duty-to-consult lever rather than an outright refusal.

Plug these in — where to find and track the file:

Registries (find and track the file): - Impact Assessment Agency of Canada / Canadian Impact Assessment Registry — canada.ca/en/impact-assessment-agency - Canada Energy Regulator — cer-rec.gc.ca - Your province’s environmental-assessment / environmental registry; your municipality’s planning portal.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

The Three Documentation Layers

Documentation transforms vague opposition (“This is bad”) into undeniable evidence (“This specific harm will occur to

these specific people/species at these specific costs”). Success comes from three layers working together.

LAYER 1: BASELINE CONDITIONS DOCUMENTATION

What it is: comprehensive documentation of existing conditions BEFORE the project begins.

Why it matters: proponents claim “it’s already disturbed” or “baseline isn’t important.” Baseline documentation proves what was there — and it cannot be reconstructed later.

Documented case — the Tsleil-Waututh Nation and the Trans Mountain expansion

Rather than rely on the proponent’s and the regulator’s assessment, the **Tsleil-Waututh Nation** (a coastal nation near Burnaby, BC) produced **its own independent assessment** of the Trans Mountain pipeline expansion in 2015. Working from its own laws and expert evidence, the Nation documented the harms the federal review had sidelined: the sharp rise in oil-tanker traffic through Burrard Inlet, the risk of a diluted-bitumen spill in the marine environment, and the impact on the endangered **Southern resident killer whale**.

In *Tsleil-Waututh Nation v Canada (Attorney General)*, 2018 FCA 153, the Federal Court of Appeal **quashed the approval**. It found the National Energy Board had made a “critical error” by unjustifiably excluding project-related **marine shipping** from the project’s scope — the very impacts the Nation had documented — so that the effects on the killer whale were never properly assessed; and it found Canada had failed to fulfil its **duty to consult**. The government did not appeal, and the project was sent back for reconsideration and further consultation.

Why it matters for you: the Nation’s own assessment identified, years in advance, the exact gap that later voided the approval. Documentation isn’t a formality — it can be the thing a court acts on.

Building your own baseline (typical process). Document existing conditions before the project starts, because a proponent will claim a site is “already disturbed” and baseline cannot be reconstructed later. A workable approach: monthly surveys across at least a season cycle — more if you can — of the project area plus upstream/downstream reference sites; a species inventory with GPS locations of breeding habitat, flagging species listed under the federal **Species at Risk Act (SARA)** (the federal law protecting listed species and their habitat) or provincial equivalents that the proponent’s review omitted; ecosystem structure (forest composition and age, riparian buffer width, wetlands); and hydrology (pH, dissolved oxygen, temperature, turbidity, seasonal flow). Typical cost is around \$5,000 for a consultant, GPS, and water-testing supplies — reducible with knowledgeable community volunteers. Dated seasonal photographs and grid-referenced maps make it credible.

LAYER 2: IMPACT ANALYSIS

What it is: detailed analysis of what specific harms will occur, based on the project description plus your baseline.

Why it matters: it shows not just “something bad” but “specifically THIS BAD in THIS WAY.”

The clever part — use the proponent’s own admissions. Impact statements routinely contain sentences like “some riparian vegetation removal is unavoidable” or “turbidity may increase during storm events.” Convert each admission into a quantified prediction against your baseline: - Turbidity: predicted 200+ NTU during storms vs. baseline 5-10 NTU - Sediment loading: multiples of the baseline tonnes/year - Temperature: a shade-loss increase that pushes a cold-water fishery out of tolerance - **Cumulative effects:** this project *plus* everything else already in the watershed — the single most common weak point in Canadian impact statements.

Outcome (illustrative): a provincial regulator found the original impact statement inadequate on cumulative and water-quality effects, required a supplemental assessment (a multi-year delay), and the harvest/footprint was cut substantially.

Cost-benefit: a modest impact-analysis investment led to a major project reduction and a multi-year delay.

LAYER 3: HEALTH & ECONOMIC IMPACT DOCUMENTATION

What it is: quantification of human-health and economic costs to the community.

Why it matters: decision-makers respond to human cost. “X species will be affected” matters less than “an estimated 45 additional respiratory cases per year, costing the local health system \$X.”

Method: use recognized air-quality modelling plus the epidemiological literature to translate emissions into health outcomes, then attach costs. Canada’s health-cost and air-quality references (Health Canada’s Air Quality Benefits Assessment Tool and peer-reviewed literature) let you estimate additional respiratory and cardiovascular cases and dollar costs for the affected population. Present it plainly: additional asthma exacerbations, new childhood asthma cases,

hospital visits, lost work days, and total annual and lifetime health cost.

Outcome (illustrative): an independent health analysis prompted the regulator to require emissions controls the original design lacked, and added many months of process.

Cost-benefit: a modest health-documentation investment led to a major emissions-control requirement.

How to Structure Your Documentation

Phase 1: Baseline Conditions (Months 1-2)

- Hire an environmental consultant (or identify knowledgeable community members — naturalists, retired scientists, students)
- Establish a survey schedule (seasonal)
- Create data-collection forms; document conditions
- **Deliverable:** 20-30 page baseline report — species/ecosystem inventory, water-quality data, seasonal patterns, dated photographs (same locations across seasons), GPS maps

Phase 2: Impact Analysis (Months 2-3)

- Obtain the proponent's project description + impact statement
- Identify specific impacts; use baseline data to predict specific harm
- **Deliverable:** 20-30 page impact analysis — quantified predicted impacts, comparison to baseline, references to the proponent's own admissions, maps/charts

Phase 3: Health/Economic Analysis (Months 3-4)

- Identify affected populations; use the epidemiological literature to predict health impacts; quantify economic costs
 - **Deliverable:** 15-20 page health/economic report — specific outcome predictions, cost quantification, comparison to regulatory thresholds, written for public/media
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Common Documentation Pitfalls (What Fails)

Pitfall 1: Waiting for Perfect Data

Documented data beats perfect data that arrives after the decision. A seasonal baseline in 3-4 months beats pristine data collected too late.

Pitfall 2: Only Environmental Data

Decision-makers respond to budget, liability, and health as much as species. Document environmental **plus** health **plus** economic impacts.

Pitfall 3: No Peer Review

A consultant's report the regulator can dismiss as "advocacy" becomes far stronger after an independent scientist reviews it. Budget \$600-1,200 for peer review; it buys credibility.

Pitfall 4: Ignoring the Proponent's Own Admissions

Quote the proponent's impact statement against itself. Their sentence "turbidity may increase during storms" is an admission you build a water-quality case on.

Documentation Budget Breakdown (CAD)

Item	Cost	Notes
Environmental consultant (80 hrs @ \$45/hr)	\$3,600	Baseline survey + species ID
GPS equipment (purchase/lease)	\$450	Mapping/documentation
Water-quality testing supplies	\$350	Sampling across seasons
Peer review (independent scientist)	\$900	Credibility + legitimacy
Printing/distribution	\$300	Copies for decision-makers
TOTAL	\$5,600	Reducible using knowledgeable community members

Cost reduction: if the budget is \$2,500-3,500, use community members for fieldwork, hire the consultant only for analysis/peer review, and lead with the strongest layer (health/economic is usually most persuasive).

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANIZE COMMUNITIES THAT HOLD

Critical Insight About Organizing

Most opposition campaigns fail not because they can't build opposition, but because opposition burns out after 4-8 months. You need organizational structures that prevent it.

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Months 1-2)

Goal: a core group of 15-20 motivated people and a clear picture of their concerns.

Step 1a: One-on-One Conversations

People don't join movements from flyers; they join from relationships. Identify the 15-20 people most affected or interested. **Call** each (don't email) for a one-hour conversation. Ask: "What's your biggest concern about this project?" Listen — don't pitch. Ask what they'd be willing to do.

Each person has a different concern (property value, health, water, a way of life). Opposition organized around each shared concern is stronger than a single generic message.

Step 1b: Affinity Groups by Concern

Organize small groups (3-8 people) around a shared concern. People who won't unite under one banner will unite around their own stake: - **Property/land group** — "the route crosses my land," compensation, devaluation - **Agricultural/water group** — soil, wells, aquifer, freshet - **Health group** — air, dust, noise, drinking water - **Environmental group** — species-at-risk, wetlands, cumulative effects - **Cultural/rights group** — where the project affects Indigenous harvesting, sites, and title (this group is led by the affected nation, not spoken for — see Step 4)

Each group meets monthly, strategizes how opposition serves *their* interest, and coordinates while keeping its distinct framing.

Step 1c: Coalition Structure (Early)

Formalize coordination between the affinity groups. Essential elements: a coalition name; the list of participating groups; a decision-making process (consensus or majority vote); a meeting schedule; a communication method; and a conflict-resolution process. A **written agreement** prevents "the coalition fell apart because one group went rogue."

PHASE 2: PUBLIC LAUNCH (Months 2-3)

Goal: announce opposition to the public, the media, and decision-makers.

Step 2a: Community Forum

Hold a public meeting where the community explains its concerns to itself, to decision-makers, and to media. A **forum** (civic engagement) beats a rally (protest) at launch, because decision-makers must attend a forum and can dismiss a rally.

Typical 3-hour agenda: welcome (10 min) → project explanation (15 min) → community concern input, each person 3-5

minutes (60 min) → expert Q&A with a scientist, a health voice, and a lawyer (20 min) → next steps (15 min). Tone: serious and informational, not emotional.

Step 2b: Opposition Materials (Factsheets)

One page. Decision-makers won't read 30 pages; one page gets read. Structure: a headline stating the problem → quick quantified facts → the specific impact → **what you're asking for** → the scientific basis → contact/resources. Print 1,000, distribute at grocery stores, libraries, band offices, community centres; post a digital version; translate into the community's languages (including French where relevant, and Indigenous languages where appropriate). Cost: ~\$300.

Step 2c: Public Petition

Decision-makers count signatures. Structure: title (the specific ask) → problem statement → the specific ask (e.g., "We petition the Minister to refuse the certificate, OR require [named conditions]") → signature section → delivery instructions. Collect door-to-door and by tabling; 500 minimum, 1,000+ better; deliver at a public/media event. Cost: ~\$50.

Step 2d: Media Coverage at Launch

Release data + petition together = a news story. (Full press-release example is in Section 8, 8G.) Email reporters after calling them; attach the study. Expect 1-3 local stories.

PHASE 3: COALITION EXPANSION (Months 3-6)

Goal: grow from 20 core people to 50+ core plus 5-10 organizations.

Step 3a: Organization Outreach

Approach environmental groups, faith organizations, labour (where health/economic issues bite), agricultural organizations, social-justice groups, and business groups. Research each; call the leader directly; explain how opposition serves *their* mission; make a specific, tailored ask.

Tailored asks: - **Environmental group:** "We need ecological expertise for the regulatory submission — can you provide pro-bono review?" - **Faith organization:** "Environmental stewardship is your mission — can your congregation host one vigil on [date]?" - **Labour union:** "Construction jobs are temporary; the health costs are permanent — will you oppose or seek conditions?" - **Agricultural organization:** "The project threatens farmland and water — can you provide impact testimony?"

Step 3b: Coalition Agreements (Written)

A written document specifying how the coalition works and what each organization commits to prevents later conflict. Elements: who's in; decision-making (consensus vs. vote); meeting frequency; the public message; who may speak for the coalition; conflict resolution; how money is handled; an exit clause. Consensus is stronger but slower; voting is faster but can fracture.

Step 3c: Coordinated Public Work

Assign leadership by strength: environmental messaging to the environmental group; economic/health to the relevant committees; media to whoever has the contacts; legal to the law organization. Sequence activities so each builds media momentum (coalition launch → data release → demonstration → petition delivery).

PHASE 4: SUSTAINED PRESSURE (Months 6-12)

Goal: maintain organized opposition across a 12+ month timeline.

Step 4a: Public Demonstrations

Monthly, same time and place, growing attendance. Structure: first Tuesday, 6-7 PM, a visible location (legislature/city hall steps), 30 minutes of signs and speeches, then a short march. Handle logistics: permits if required, childcare, accessibility, a sound system for 100+. Momentum matters: "50 protest" becomes "protest swells to 200" as attendance grows.

Step 4b: Media Campaign (Ongoing)

Monthly rhythm: week 1 a news release tied to an event/data; weeks 2-3 social media 3x/week; week 4 a reporter check-in call. Rotate release themes (petition milestone → expert finding → coalition growth → demonstration → economic analysis → decision deadline).

Step 4c: Common Opposition Failure Points (How to Prevent)

Failure Point 1: Burnout (Months 4-8). Prevent it: monthly (not weekly) meetings; celebrate milestones; fund one part-time organizer (~\$500-800/month) so volunteers don't carry logistics; schedule explicit breaks; keep a public progress tracker. A campaign that hired a part-time coordinator when its founders burned out has sustained for years; one that didn't collapsed at month six.

Failure Point 2: Coalition Conflict. Prevent it with a written agreement and decision process, a clear escalation path (discuss → mediator), an explicit exit clause, and rotating leadership so no single organization controls the coalition.

Failure Point 3: Competing Funding. Grants with conflicting conditions can pull organizations off shared work. Coordinate grants up front, seek coalition-level grants, and agree that no org commits coalition resources to grant-funded work without a coalition decision.

Failure Point 4: No Clear Wins. Prevent hopelessness by naming milestones as victories (500 signatures, a 200-person demonstration, a media story) and publicizing cumulative progress.

Opposition Building Budget: Year-Long Campaign (CAD)

Item	Cost
Factsheet printing (1,000 copies)	\$350
Website/email hosting (annual)	\$250
Meeting supplies (coffee, accessibility)	\$350
Outreach transportation	\$450
Petition collection supplies	\$50
Demonstration supplies (signs, sound)	\$650
Coalition meeting expenses	\$250
Part-time organizer stipend (10 hrs/wk × \$22/hr × 52)	\$11,440
Social-media management (3 months part-time)	\$1,700
Fundraiser/event costs	\$800
TOTAL	\$16,290

Reductions: drop the paid organizer to run a shorter 6-month campaign, or use a volunteer coordinator, to cut ~\$11,000.

Funding the campaign. Money typically comes from four places: individual donations (door-to-door, petition-signer follow-up, online); grants from environmental, community, and social-justice funders (long lead times — apply early); benefit events (a dinner, house parties); and in-kind support from coalition organizations (staff time, meeting space). West Coast Environmental Law's Environmental Dispute Resolution Fund can also grant money toward a community's own legal costs. Aim to raise half the budget by month 6 and the rest by month 12.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — HOW TO USE CANADA'S REGULATORS AND COURTS

Plug these in — who fights beside you (many free of charge):

Free / low-cost legal help: - **Ecojustice** — *ecojustice.ca* — Canada's largest environmental-law charity; litigates at every level of court, free of charge. National. - **West Coast Environmental Law (WCEL)** — *wcel.org* — free legal advice, plus grants through its Environmental Dispute Resolution Fund toward a community's own legal costs; bridges Indigenous and Canadian law. - **Canadian Environmental Law Association (CELA)** — *cela.ca* — free legal services for lower-income and vulnerable communities in Ontario, funded by Legal Aid Ontario. - **East Coast Environmental Law** — Atlantic Canada.

Case law: **CanLII** — *canlii.org* — free access to Canadian court and tribunal decisions.

Records: federal *Access to Information* requests; each province's Freedom of Information law.

Health: Canadian Association of Physicians for the Environment (**CAPE**).

- **A key advantage:** Canada's leading environmental-law charities represent communities **free of charge**, so a strong case is not gated by the ability to pay.

Canadian legal strategy has three tracks, and one of them — the duty to consult — is uniquely powerful.

TRACK 1: REGULATORY PARTICIPATION (the front door)

Both federal regulators build public participation into the process, and using it well creates the record you will need later.

Impact Assessment Agency of Canada (IAAC). The agency runs a multi-stage process with formal **public comment periods** and encourages participation; it also serves as the **Crown Consultation Coordinator** for Indigenous consultation. Comments filed on the record shape the conditions attached to any approval — and become evidence if the decision is later challenged. File specific, evidence-based comments during each open window; cite your Step 2 documentation.

Canada Energy Regulator (CER). For pipelines and power lines, members of the public can take part as a **Commentator** (file a *letter of comment* setting out concerns) or, for those more directly affected, as an **Intervenor** — a role that carries the right to be heard, to test the proponent's evidence, to receive the decision and its reasons, and in some cases to have participation costs funded. Intervenor status is the strongest non-court tool the public has in an energy proceeding.

Provincial EA processes and municipal hearings have their own comment and appeal routes — use every one; a federal approval is worthless to a proponent who cannot get a provincial water licence or a municipal rezoning.

Why this track matters: filing well — specific, on time, grounded in evidence — often does more than filing loudly, and it lays the foundation for Tracks 2 and 3.

TRACK 2: THE DUTY TO CONSULT — CANADA'S STRONGEST LEVER

This is the most powerful tool in Canadian law for communities affected by development. Understand it before anything else.

Section 35 of the *Constitution Act, 1982* recognizes and affirms the existing Aboriginal and treaty rights of Indigenous peoples. From it flows the **Crown's duty to consult and accommodate** Indigenous peoples whenever a decision might adversely affect their rights — the doctrine established in *Haida Nation v. British Columbia*. This duty is **constitutional**: legislation cannot abrogate it, and even Canada's recent fast-track laws for "national interest" projects expressly leave it in place.

What it means in practice: - When a project affects Indigenous rights and the Crown consults inadequately, courts can and do **quash the approval**. The landmark case is the **Trans Mountain expansion**: in 2018 the **Federal Court of Appeal** (*Tsleil-Waututh Nation v. Canada*) overturned the federal approval because Canada had failed to meaningfully consult First Nations and because the regulator had wrongly excluded marine-shipping impacts. The project proceeded only after the government redid the consultation. - **Consultation is not (yet) a veto**. Canadian law generally requires the Crown to consult and, where appropriate, accommodate — not to obtain consent on most Crown land. Campaigns that overstate this get blindsided; state it accurately. - **UNDRIP is shifting the ground**. The federal *United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples Act* (2021) and British Columbia's *Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples Act* (DRIPA, 2019) commit governments to align their laws with UNDRIP and its principle of **free, prior and informed consent**. Courts are still working out how much independent legal force these carry — the *Gitxaala* litigation over BC's "free entry" mineral-claims system, and the 2025-26 political fights over DRIPA, show this is a live, fast-moving area. **Get current legal advice before relying on it.**

How non-Indigenous allies engage this track: the affected nation is a rights-holder that leads its own legal strategy. Allies support that leadership when invited; they never speak for it or launch duty-to-consult litigation on its behalf. Done with respect and on the nation's terms, this alliance has been decisive in the biggest Canadian wins.

TRACK 3: JUDICIAL REVIEW AND STATUTORY CHALLENGES

Most legal challenges to Canadian approvals are **applications for judicial review** — asking a court to find the decision unlawful because the decision-maker exceeded its authority, ignored a required factor, breached procedural fairness, or (for Indigenous applicants) failed the duty to consult. Federal decisions go to the **Federal Court** or **Federal Court of Appeal**; provincial decisions go to that province's superior court.

There are, functionally, three sub-types:

TYPE 1: REGULATORY / ADMINISTRATIVE CHALLENGE (fastest, cheapest)

Challenge the decision through the tribunal's own process or a prompt judicial review where the approval violates the

governing statute (e.g., the impact statement failed to assess cumulative effects the *Impact Assessment Act* requires; the province ignored its own EA-act requirements). File within the short statutory window. Pair it with your regulatory comments from Track 1. A law-school environmental clinic or one of the charities below can often carry this at little or no cost.

TYPE 2: ENVIRONMENTAL LITIGATION (longer, more expensive)

File in court challenging the approval's legal validity, often paired with a motion to stay/injunct construction pending the outcome. Canadian statutes that ground these cases include the **Impact Assessment Act**, the **Fisheries Act** (harm to fish and fish habitat), the **Species at Risk Act** (SARA, effects on listed species and critical habitat), the **Migratory Birds Convention Act**, and the **Canadian Environmental Protection Act** (CEPA — whose 2023 amendments recognized, for the first time in Canadian law, a right to a healthy environment). Most such cases settle or resolve into conditions; the strongest also carry duty-to-consult grounds under Track 2.

TYPE 3: POST-APPROVAL / COMPLIANCE CHALLENGE (highest success rate)

Once a project is operating, sue for breach of its conditions or permits (discharges above limits, habitat destruction beyond what was authorized). These have the highest success rate of the three because the violation is concrete and documented, and can force shutdowns of offending equipment, added mitigation, or reduced operations.

Standing. Canadian courts recognize **public-interest standing**, so a community group or NGO — not only a directly affected landowner — can often bring a case where a serious justiciable issue is raised and there is no better-placed challenger.

Legal Strategy Decision Tree

```
START: Is a federal impact assessment or CER proceeding underway?
├ YES → File comments / seek Intervenor status NOW (Track 1). Build the record.
└ NO → Identify the provincial/municipal approval and its comment/appeal route.

Q1: Does the project affect Indigenous rights or territory?
├ YES → The affected nation leads. Support the duty-to-consult track (Track 2).
│     This is often the strongest available challenge.
└ NO / UNCLEAR → Continue.

Q2: Is there a clear legal/statutory defect in the decision?
├ NO (process followed, you just disagree) → No strong judicial review; focus on opposition + media.
├ UNCLEAR → Free initial consult with an environmental-law charity (below).
└ YES → Continue.

Q3: Budget available?
├ $0 → Approach Ecojustice / WCEL / CELA (free); pursue Track 1 + duty-to-consult support.
├ $0-5K → Regulatory challenge / early judicial review with clinic help; file within the window.
├ $5-30K → Judicial review + injunction prep, combined with opposition.
└ $30K+ → Full litigation + stay motion; timeline 12-24 months; pair with opposition + media.

Q4: Is the harm imminent/irreversible once construction starts?
├ YES → Seek an interlocutory injunction / stay immediately.
└ NO → Judicial review proceeds on the normal timeline.

RECOMMENDED PATHS
Path A – Strong statutory defect + limited budget:
  Track 1 comments + prompt judicial review (clinic/charity) + build opposition.
Path B – Indigenous rights affected:
  Support the nation's duty-to-consult challenge (Track 2) + Track 1 + media. Highest ceiling.
Path C – Weak legal case:
  Don't litigate. Focus on opposition + media to create political cost and win conditions.
```

Litigation Success Factors

Litigation succeeds when **combined** with the other steps: - Litigation alone: 20-30% - Litigation + opposition: 35-45% - Litigation + opposition + media: 50-70% - Litigation with a well-founded **duty-to-consult** ground: can exceed these, because the court is applying a constitutional standard the Crown cannot sidestep.

A judge who sees a serious legal claim **plus** visible political opposition **plus** media coverage treats the matter as serious and is likelier to grant a stay or push a settlement/redo. The Trans Mountain quashing is the clearest Canadian illustration: a strong consultation claim, sustained First Nations leadership, and heavy media together produced a Federal Court of Appeal decision that stopped a federally-backed pipeline in its tracks.

What to Avoid: Legal Failures

- **Litigating instead of organizing.** A lone technical claim with no visible opposition and no media reads to a court as a niche dispute. Build opposition first; litigate with it visible.
 - **Litigating too late.** Miss the short judicial-review window and you're reduced to cleanup after construction starts. Act within the statutory deadline.
 - **Weak arguments.** "This project is bad for the environment" is a policy opinion. "The assessment failed to consider cumulative effects as required by the *Impact Assessment Act*" is a legal claim a court can rule on.
 - **Speaking for a nation.** Never launch or frame a duty-to-consult claim on behalf of an Indigenous nation. Support; don't appropriate.
-

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Canada has a strong independent-media ecosystem that covers exactly these fights — and a documented record of that coverage changing outcomes.

How Journalists Actually Work

What reporters care about, in order: (1) **news** (something new happened), (2) **consequence** (someone is affected), (3) **timeliness** (it's happening now), (4) **conflict** (there's a real dispute), (5) **new information** (this was not known before). What they don't care about: your opinion, how angry you are, vague statements, or meetings with no news hook.

The Newsworthiness Formula

NEWS = DATA + CONSEQUENCE + TIMELINESS + NEW INFORMATION

- **Bad:** "Community opposes the mine." (no data, no specific consequence, no timeliness, nothing new) → ignored.
- **Good:** "Independent study: mine tailings put drinking water for 8,000 people at risk; decision due March 15." (data + consequence + timeliness + new info) → covered.

The difference is roughly a 4-5x change in the likelihood of coverage.

Know the Outlets That Cover This Beat

- **The Narwhal** (*thenarwhal.ca*) — an independent, ad-free non-profit newsroom devoted to environmental and natural-world investigative journalism, with bureaus across the country. It exists to hold this kind of decision-making to account.
- **Canada's National Observer** (*nationalobserver.com*) — independent investigative outlet. Its 2016 reporting revealed that regulator panel members had met privately with a consultant to the proponent (former Quebec premier Jean Charest); the three panellists recused themselves, and the proponent later cancelled the \$15.7-billion pipeline.
- **CBC, The Tyee**, regional dailies, and Indigenous-run outlets such as **APTN** for reach into general and community audiences.

Building Reporter Relationships (The Key)

Reporters don't call opposition for comment; opposition calls reporters with news tips. Identify 5-10 local/regional reporters (environment, health, and the legislature/Queen's Park/city-hall beats). **Call** first (email gets deleted): "I noticed you covered [similar story]. We have a similar situation in [place] and I think your readers should know. Do you have 20 minutes this week?" Then build the relationship over months — send them a relevant article, a data tip, a milestone update — so that by the time you have a big story, they already know you.

Sample Media Timeline

- Month 1: establish relationships (call five reporters; get on their radar)
- Month 2: first story (petition results)
- Month 3: press conference releasing the study; expert available
- Month 4: coalition announcement
- Month 5: demonstration coverage
- Month 6: decision-deadline coverage

Real Media Dynamics (Canadian grounding)

- **Investigation topples a project (Energy East):** independent reporting (Canada’s National Observer, 2016) that panel members had met privately with a consultant to the proponent — former Quebec premier Jean Charest — sparked outrage in Quebec and led the three panellists to recuse themselves, a major blow to an already unpopular pipeline, which the proponent then cancelled. Documents beat press releases.
- **A human story shifts politics:** a multi-generation farm family or a nation’s harvesters, photographed on the land the project would cross, connects emotionally and moves legislators who fear the optics.
- **Scientific credibility beats industry claims:** an independent, peer-reviewed analysis that contradicts a proponent’s optimistic study lets media write “scientists dispute the proponent’s numbers,” and regulators take the opposition seriously.

Plug these in — the outlets and desks that cover this beat:

Investigative media: The Narwhal (*thenarwhal.ca*); Canada’s National Observer (*nationalobserver.com*); CBC; The Tyee; APTN.

Media Measurement Track cumulative stories and reach month over month. Success indicators: regular (at least monthly) coverage that carries your message and specific data, and visible decision-maker response. Failure indicators: no coverage for 2+ months, superficial coverage that omits your argument, or no decision-maker response.
--

HOW THE FIVE STEPS COMPOUND

Now that all five steps are on the table, here is how they stack — and which ones carry the most weight when combined.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (Approval Modified/Denied/Withdrawn)

CLEAN DECISION SCENARIO:

All 5 Steps Combined:  65-75%

4 Steps Combined:  55-65%

3 Steps Combined:  45-55%

2 Steps Combined:  30-40%

Single Step:  5-20%

WITH MODERATE TILT FACTORS:

(Some royalty dependence or proponent-funded assessment)

All 5 Steps Combined:  40-45%

4 Steps Combined:  30-40%

3 Steps Combined:  20-30%

2 Steps Combined:  15-25%

Single Step:  3-12%

WITH SEVERE TILT FACTORS:

(Heavy royalty dependence, proponent-only assessment, "free entry" tenure)

All 5 Steps Combined:  25-30%

4 Steps Combined:  18-24%

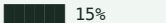
3 Steps Combined:  12-18%

2 Steps Combined:  8-15%

Single Step:  2-8%

One important exception: where an Indigenous nation whose rights are affected leads a duty-to-consult challenge, these ceilings can be exceeded even in resource regions where the system is heavily tilted — because the duty is constitutional and cannot be legislated away.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **OPPOSITION BUILDING** (Step 3)  25%
Why: creates political pressure, visible to decision-makers, enables other steps
2. **DOCUMENTATION** (Step 2)  22%
Why: provides ammunition for legal/media, grounds opposition in facts
3. **MEDIA STRATEGY** (Step 5)  20%
Why: makes opposition/legal/documentation visible, creates political cost
4. **LEGAL CHALLENGES** (Step 4)  18%
Why: buys time, creates regulatory/court pressure — and in Canada holds the duty-to-consult lever
5. **TARGET ID** (Step 1)  15%
Why: foundation — if wrong, everything fails

Real insight: a large, organized, visible community — standing in respectful alliance with affected Indigenous nations — is more persuasive than perfect documentation or brilliant legal arguments on their own.

SECTION 8: EMAILS & LETTERS YOU CAN COPY

These are ready-to-use messages. Adapt the bracketed parts and send them. Keep them short, specific, and factual — that is what gets read and acted on. The legal-challenge letter and press release from the original toolkit are kept here as 8F and 8G.

8A. Email to a reporter (story pitch)

Subject: Story tip: [specific finding] – decision due [date]

Hi [Reporter first name],

I follow your coverage of [beat / recent story]. We have something in [place] your readers should know about, and there's a clear news hook.

In one line: [independent study / new record] shows [quantified finding – e.g. "the proposed mine puts drinking water for 8,000 people at risk"], and [regulator / Minister] decides on [date].

Why it's newsworthy: it's new (just released), specific (affects [# people / hectares / species]), and time-sensitive (decision [date]).

I can send the full study and connect you with [one named expert] for an interview. Would a quick call this week work?

Thanks,
[Name] – [Organization] – [phone] – [email]

8B. Email / letter to a decision-maker

Subject: Please [refuse the certificate / impose conditions] on [project] – [file no.]

Dear [Councillor / MLA / MP / Minister] [Name],

I am a constituent in [community] writing about [project], file [number], before [regulator], with a decision expected [date].

The concern, briefly: [one or two specific, quantified harms – e.g. "the assessment does not analyze cumulative effects on the [X] watershed, and the proponent's own filing admits [quote]"].

I am asking you to [specific, achievable action – e.g. "publicly urge the Minister to refuse the certificate," or "support binding conditions: a [500 m] stream buffer, a [\$20M] reclamation bond, and independent Indigenous-led monitoring"].

[If true:] [#] residents have signed a petition to this effect, and these organizations share the position: [list].

I would welcome a meeting and can provide our full documentation.

Sincerely,
[Name], [address in the riding / ward], [phone], [email]

8C. Public comment submission (to the regulator)

Subject: Public comment – [project name], [registry / file number]

To: [Impact Assessment Agency of Canada / Canada Energy Regulator / provincial EA office], [comment portal or email]

Re: Comment on [project], [CIAR / CER file number]. Comment period closes [date].

1. Who I am: [name / organization], [community], [interest in the project].
2. Specific concerns, with evidence:
 - a. [Concern – e.g. cumulative effects]. The assessment [omits / underestimates] this. Evidence: [your baseline / impact data; the proponent's own admission, quoted]. This engages [the Impact Assessment Act's requirement to assess cumulative effects / the Fisheries Act / the Species at Risk Act].
 - b. [Concern 2 – water, species-at-risk, health]. Evidence: [...].
3. What I am asking for: [that the impact statement be found inadequate on [issue] and returned; OR that these binding conditions be imposed: [list]].

Please confirm receipt and add this to the public record.

[Name] – [Organization] – [contact]
Attachments: [baseline report / impact analysis / health analysis]

8D. Coalition outreach email (to an organization)

Subject: [Organization] + [project] – a specific ask that fits your mission

Hi [Leader name],

I'm [name] with [group] in [community]. We're working on [project], which [one-line stake]. I'm reaching out because this connects directly to [organization]'s work on [their mission / issue].

We're not asking you to adopt our whole campaign – just one concrete thing that serves your mission: [tailored ask – e.g. "pro-bono ecological review of the impact statement," or "a letter of comment on the record by [date]," or "co-leading the health message"].

If helpful, I can send a one-page brief and hop on a 20-minute call.

Thanks for considering it,
[Name] – [Organization] – [contact]

8E. Records request (Access to Information / FOI)

Subject: Access to Information / Freedom of Information request – [project]

To: [federal institution's ATIP office / the province's FOI coordinator]

Under the [Access to Information Act (federal) / (Province) Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act], I request records concerning [project / file number], including:

- correspondence between [regulator / ministry] and [proponent], [date] to [date];
- the proponent-funded studies underlying the assessment, and any staff review of them;
- records of meetings between [decision-makers] and [proponent];
- [any specific document you know exists].

Please provide records electronically. If fees will exceed [\$25], contact me first with an estimate. If any record is withheld, cite the specific exemption.

[Name] – [address] – [email]

8F. Judicial review / regulatory challenge letter

NOTE: In Canada most challenges to an approval are applications for JUDICIAL REVIEW (Federal Court / Federal Court of Appeal for federal decisions; provincial superior court for provincial decisions), or challenges through a tribunal's own process. Deadlines are SHORT (often days to weeks) – confirm the exact window with counsel immediately. the organizations named in Step 4 act free of charge.

APPLICATION FOR JUDICIAL REVIEW OF [DECISION]
[Date]

TO: [Court] – RE: Judicial review of [decision], [file / permit no.], dated [date]

APPLICANT: [Organization / individual / (or supporting an affected First Nation)]
Contact: [Name, phone, email, address]
Standing: [directly affected] OR [public-interest standing: serious issue, genuine interest, no better-placed challenger]

DECISION UNDER REVIEW: decision-maker; what was approved; date; filing deadline.

GROUND:

1. [Statutory defect] – e.g. "the assessment failed to consider cumulative effects as required by the Impact Assessment Act." Provision: "[cite]."
The record shows: "[quote / the proponent's own admission]."
2. [Procedural fairness] – required process vs. what actually happened.
3. [Duty to consult] (where applicable, led by the affected nation) – the Crown failed to consult and accommodate as required by s.35 of the Constitution Act, 1982 (Haida Nation), as in Tsileil-Waututh Nation v. Canada (Trans Mountain).
4. [SARA / Fisheries Act / Migratory Birds / CEPA] – effects on listed species, fish habitat, migratory birds, or the right to a healthy environment.

RELIEF SOUGHT: quash the decision; remit for reconsideration with proper consultation / assessment; [if harm is imminent] an interlocutory stay pending outcome.

CERTIFICATION / signature / date

ATTACHMENTS: the decision; the assessment (key pages); applicable statutes; supporting evidence; relevant case law; maps / photos.

8G. Press release (effective)

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

[HEADLINE: make it NEWS, not opinion]
[Subtitle: consequence + timeliness]

[DATELINE: City / Date]

[LEAD – answer "why now?"]
[Local group] released [study / findings] today showing [specific finding] affecting [# of people / hectares / species].

KEY FINDINGS

- [Quantified impact with citation]
- [Quantified impact with citation]
- [Quantified impact with citation]

[DIRECT QUOTE – specific, from a credible voice, not a slogan]
"[What the finding means]," said [Name, Title].

[CONTEXT – why it matters; comparison to a documented Canadian case]

[DECISION POINT – create urgency]
[Regulator / Minister] decides on [date]. Public comment closes [date].

[CALL TO ACTION] To comment: [how]. For more: [contact].

CONTACT: [Name / Organization / Phone / Email]
ATTACHMENTS: full study, technical summary, methodology, maps, Q&A

8H. Legal strategy decision tree

See Step 4 for the full decision tree — Tracks 1-3, the budget branches, and the duty-to-consult path, which is often the strongest lever in Canada.

SECTION 9: WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED TOWARD APPROVAL (HONEST MECHANICS)

What this means. A system is **tilted toward approval** when the bodies that decide on a project lean, in practice, toward approving it — because they depend on the industry's money or jobs, rely on the proponent's own information, or face strong political pressure to say yes. It rarely means anyone broke the law. Here is how it works — and how communities win anyway.

Important Caveat

This section describes patterns from documented Canadian cases and public records — a system tilted toward approval, resource-revenue dependence, proponent-funded assessment, and the courts' heavy use of injunctions against blockades. It is not a statistical claim about "X% of all decisions." Read it as: "where these patterns appear, here is what happens and what it means for opposition."

What This Tilt DOES (and DOESN'T DO)

DOES: create financial incentive for approval (royalties, jobs, tax base); bias information (proponent-funded assessments read optimistically); advantage well-resourced parties; and arm proponents with **civil injunctions and contempt-of-court powers** against blockades, so that opposition on the land becomes a legal risk for participants. **DOESN'T:** guarantee approval; make opposition impossible; eliminate the duty to consult (which is constitutional and cannot be removed by any tilt in the system); or prevent delays, modifications, and political costs.

Analogy: a tilted system is like playing against a team that owns the referee. It makes winning harder, not impossible — so your strategy has to be sharper and more visible, so other observers see the bias.

Documented Canadian Dynamics

Regulator bias exposed (Energy East). Investigative reporting (Canada's National Observer, 2016) revealed that members of the federal energy regulator's review panel had met privately with a consultant to the proponent — former Quebec premier Jean Charest. Amid complaints of bias the three panellists recused themselves in 2016, a new panel voided their earlier work, the review's credibility collapsed in Quebec, and the proponent cancelled the \$15.7-billion project in 2017. **Lesson:** exposing a tilted process can be more powerful than arguing inside it.

"Free entry" tenure (Gitxaala). BC's automated online mineral-claim system granted claims on Crown land with no up-

front consultation. First Nations challenged it; the courts found the province owed a duty to consult, and BC replaced the regime. **Lesson:** even a system built for the proponent can be forced open through the duty to consult.

Royalty/revenue dependence. Where a province or community depends heavily on resource revenue, political pressure to approve can exceed what public opposition alone can overcome — but opposition still routinely wins delays, smaller footprints, and mitigation funds, and the duty-to-consult track remains available regardless.

Assessment Framework — Determine Your Situation

GREEN FLAG (low tilt): independent assessment available; regulator denies some projects; a clear statutory defect exists; no free-entry tenure; strong duty-to-consult footing. → 65-75% with all 5 steps. Proceed with standard opposition.

YELLOW FLAG (moderate tilt): proponent-funded assessment (but independent review possible); high approval rate; revenue dependence present; legal case arguable but not clear-cut. → 40-45% with all 5 steps; often win modifications even if not a refusal. Proceed; prepare for multiple outcomes; prioritize the duty-to-consult track and modifications.

RED FLAG (high tilt): proponent-only assessment; near-total approval rate; heavy revenue dependence; free-entry tenure; challenge relies on interpretation. → 25-30% to stop; 50-60% to modify/delay. Decide whether delay/modification justifies the investment; lead with the duty-to-consult track (often the only lever with real force here); build power for the next fight.

Direct Action: Factual Information (Descriptive, Not Prescriptive)

When legal and political paths are exhausted, some Canadian communities and land defenders have engaged in direct action — old-growth blockades (Fairy Creek, BC, where policing led to over a thousand arrests), and blockades of pipeline and resource projects on contested territory. This is descriptive of what has occurred, not guidance.

Documented consequences under Canadian law: proponents frequently obtain **civil injunctions**; breaching an injunction exposes participants to **contempt of court** (fines and jail), separate from criminal charges such as **mischief** or obstruction. A record can affect employment, travel, and professional licensing. Direct action has produced delays and disproportionate media attention in documented cases, but on its own rarely stops a project permanently; combined with legal and organizing work it is more consequential. Participants should understand the specific legal risks — including injunction/contempt — before acting, and seek legal advice.

A security-culture note — the aboveground/underground line. Security writers in the resistance literature draw one hard distinction that everyone weighing any form of action should understand. Everything in this guide — the filings, the coalitions, the hearings, the media work — is **aboveground** organizing, and it only works in the open: “There is no way to effectively do aboveground work and keep your identity hidden... Aboveground movements can only build numbers and public solidarity by being public, open, and expressing support of the movement” (dgrnewsservice.org/civilization/repression/an-introduction-to-security-for-activists-organizers-and-revolutionaries/). The same literature is equally blunt about the choice itself: “every person in a resistance movement must decide for her- or himself whether to be aboveground or underground. It is essential that this decision be made; to attempt to straddle the line is unsafe for everyone” (dgrnewsservice.org/resistance/organizational-structures-for-resistance-movements/). Whatever any individual decides, mixing the two modes endangers both that person and everyone organizing beside them — an aboveground campaign is safest, strongest, and most credible when it is exactly what it appears to be.

Honest Assessment

Where the system is tilted, opposition using legal and political methods has lower odds of an outright stop — but still reliably delays projects (often years), forces modifications and mitigation, imposes political cost, builds durable community power, and creates a record for appeals. And in Canada, the constitutional duty to consult means that even a heavily tilted provincial process can be overturned in court when Indigenous rights are affected and consultation falls short. Neither scenario makes opposition futile.

SECTION 10: WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION (AND HOW TO EXPOSE IT)

Section 9 covered a system **tilted toward approval** — pressures that are usually lawful. This section covers something narrower and more serious: **actual corruption** — the unlawful or unethical use of a public position for private benefit, or improper influence over a decision. It is rarer than ordinary bias, but where it exists it is both a wrong worth exposing and, strategically, a project's single greatest vulnerability. Handle it carefully: the same facts that can sink a project can expose you to a defamation suit if you get them wrong.

How big is the problem? The most widely cited figure comes from the World Economic Forum: corruption costs at least

US\$2.6 trillion a year — about 5% of global GDP — a figure cited before the UN Security Council. Because it is a percentage, the dollar amount grows with the world economy: applied to 2022 global GDP (~US\$101 trillion) it works out to roughly **US\$5 trillion a year**, and a January 2026 Baker Tilly analysis, with global GDP projected at ~US\$115 trillion for 2025, puts it at approximately **US\$5.75 trillion annually**. Roughly one dollar in twenty moving through the world's economy is lost to corruption — and infrastructure, land, and extractives are where it concentrates.

What counts as corruption (a spectrum from illegal to merely unethical)

- **Bribery and kickbacks** — money, jobs, or favours in exchange for a decision or a permit.
- **Undisclosed conflicts of interest** — a decision-maker with a hidden financial stake in the outcome (land near the site, shares in the proponent, a contract, a family member employed by the company).
- **The revolving door** — officials and the proponent's staff or consultants moving between each other; a former regulator now lobbying their old body.
- **Improper gifts, travel, hospitality, or political donations** flowing from a proponent to the people deciding its project.
- **Insider land speculation** — acquiring affected land using non-public knowledge of a coming decision.
- **Falsified or suppressed assessments** — a consultant delivering a predetermined result, or officials burying adverse findings.
- **Procurement fraud, nepotism, and cronyism** — steering contracts or approvals to insiders.
- **Improper pressure and undisclosed lobbying** — a recommendation quietly reversed after private contact.

Red flags to watch for

- A decision that overrides the professional or regulatory-staff recommendation with thin or shifting reasons.
- Sudden reversals, rushed timelines, or an approval pushed through quietly.
- A decision-maker who did not disclose a relevant interest, or who should have recused and didn't.
- Off-record meetings between the proponent and decision-makers (this was central to the Energy East collapse — see below).
- Donations, gifts, trips, or jobs flowing from the proponent (or its principals) to decision-makers or their families.
- A decision-maker — or a relative — owning affected land or a stake in the proponent.
- The same small circle of firms, consultants, and officials recurring across decisions.
- Missing minutes, unusual redactions, "lost" records, or stonewalling on disclosure.

How to document and investigate it (follow the money — carefully)

- **Access-to-information requests** (federal ATIP; your province's freedom-of-information law) for correspondence, calendars and meeting logs, consultant contracts, and internal assessments.
- **Public disclosures of interest** that ministers, senior officials, and (in many places) councillors must file.
- **Lobbying registries** — the federal **Office of the Commissioner of Lobbying** and your province's registry — to see who has been lobbying whom, and when.
- **Land-titles registries** and **corporate registries** — who owns the affected land and who profits.
- **Minutes, agendas, and voting records** — compare the decision to the staff or panel recommendation.
- **Build a timeline:** interest or relationship → meeting or donation → decision. Corruption is almost always shown by **pattern and timing**, not a confession.
- **Whistleblowers** often break these stories. Protect them; understand the available whistleblower protections before asking anyone to come forward.

The legal lever: bias can void a decision (even without proof of a bribe)

A decision can be set aside for a **reasonable apprehension of bias** even without proof of an actual bribe. Canadian courts ask whether an informed person, viewing the matter realistically and practically, would think it more likely than not that the decision-maker — consciously or not — would not decide fairly (the standard from *Committee for Justice and Liberty v. National Energy Board*). An **undisclosed conflict of interest**, or a decision-maker who met privately with the proponent, can meet that test. So documenting an undisclosed interest is not only a media story — it can be a **legal ground on judicial review**.

Where to report it

- The federal **Conflict of Interest and Ethics Commissioner** (for federal office-holders).
- Your **provincial integrity / conflict-of-interest commissioner**, and the **municipal integrity commissioner** where one exists.

- The **Office of the Commissioner of Lobbying** (federal) and the provincial lobbying registrar for breaches of lobbying rules.
- The **Auditor General** (federal or provincial) for misspending, and the **provincial Ombudsman** for maladministration.
- The **RCMP** or local police for suspected bribery or fraud.
- **Investigative outlets** — The Narwhal, Canada’s National Observer — in parallel with the official channels.

Strategy: exposing a tainted process can beat a project

The clearest Canadian example is **Energy East**. Investigative reporting (Canada’s National Observer, 2016) revealed that members of the federal energy regulator’s review panel had met privately with a consultant to the proponent, former Quebec premier Jean Charest. The three panellists recused themselves, a new panel voided their earlier work, the review’s credibility collapsed, and the proponent cancelled the \$15.7-billion pipeline. A credible, documented corruption story triggers investigations; it can void a decision for bias; it flips media coverage; it splits the political support behind a project; and it damages the proponent’s reputation and financing. **Exposing a tainted process is often more powerful than arguing inside it.**

Do this responsibly — and safely

- **Stick to documented facts.** Publish the records and the timeline and let readers draw conclusions; frame anything unproven as a question, not an accusation.
- **Mind defamation.** Publicly accusing a named person of a crime you cannot prove is legally dangerous. Work with a lawyer and an experienced journalist before publishing allegations.
- **Report through official channels in parallel** with any media, so there is a formal record and an investigation can follow.
- **Protect whistleblowers and sources.**
- **Don’t cry “corruption” without evidence.** Calling ordinary, lawful bias (Section 9) “corruption” destroys your credibility and can expose you to suit. Keep the two separate — which is exactly why they are separate sections here.

INTEGRATION: HOW ALL FIVE STEPS WORK TOGETHER

Realistic 12-Month Campaign Timeline

Months 1-2 — Foundation + Documentation: identify the target (Step 1); begin baseline (Step 2); begin organizing one-on-ones and affinity groups (Step 3); file early regulatory comments and first reporter calls (Steps 4-5). *Outcome:* structure forming, record beginning.

Months 2-3 — Public Launch: baseline complete; community forum + petition (Step 3); media event (Step 5). *Outcome:* opposition visible, 500+ signatures, 3-5 stories.

Months 3-4 — Coalition + Impact Analysis: complete impact analysis (Step 2); expand coalition to 5-10 orgs (Step 3); file judicial review / secure Intervenor status, and support the duty-to-consult track (Step 4); data-release press conference (Step 5). *Outcome:* broad coalition, legal challenge live, coverage expanding.

Months 4-6 — Expansion + Health Data: health/economic report (Step 2); sustained monthly demonstrations (Step 3); regulatory challenge proceeding (Step 4); expert pressers (Step 5). *Outcome:* 10+ orgs, quantified health impacts, regional media.

Months 6-9 — Escalation + Litigation: demonstrations escalating (Step 3); litigation/stay motion if the challenge advances, duty-to-consult case proceeding (Step 4); ongoing monthly media (Step 5). *Outcome:* sustained pressure, court process live.

Months 9-12 — Peak Pressure + Positioning: maintain opposition (Step 3); hearings/settlement/redo positioning (Step 4); media momentum (Step 5). *Outcome:* legal + opposition + media compound; conditions, refusal, redo, or withdrawal.

Warning Signs — Act Early

Watch for these and respond fast: attendance declining around months 4-5 (burnout); coalition members leaving (conflict or leadership problem); no media coverage for 2-3 months (media strategy failing); the legal challenge stalling; fundraising below half your target by month 6; a core organizer leaving without a successor; or someone new pushing illegal tactics. Each has a fix earlier in this guide — catch it early and the campaign holds.

Key Principles (What Separates Winning Campaigns from Losing Ones)

1. **Specificity** — “refuse the certificate by March 15 for inadequate cumulative-effects analysis,” not “we oppose the mine.”
 2. **Multi-tactic pressure** — legal + opposition + media together, not one alone.
 3. **Long-term organizing** — sustain 12+ months; prevent burnout.
 4. **Documentation first** — build the evidence, then organize and litigate on it.
 5. **Coalition building** — 5-10 diverse organizations, and respectful alliance with affected nations.
 6. **Political pressure, not just legal** — law buys time; opposition and media create political cost.
 7. **Use the constitutional lever** — where Indigenous rights are engaged, the duty to consult is often the strongest card, led by the affected nation.
 8. **Realistic expectations** — expect conditions/modifications/delay; a refusal or withdrawal is the bonus.
 9. **Persistence** — plan for 12-24 months and keep momentum.
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FINAL ASSESSMENT: OUTCOMES & WHEN TO REASSESS

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

- **Approval refused / project withdrawn** (rarer): usually requires overwhelming opposition + a strong legal or duty-to-consult case + heavy media + a system that isn't heavily tilted. Canadian examples of “inevitable” projects that ended: Northern Gateway, Energy East, Teck Frontier.
- **Project modified** (most common victory): route change, smaller footprint, buffers, binding conditions, mitigation and reclamation funds — frequently via a settlement or a court-ordered redo (as when Trans Mountain's approval was quashed and reworked).
- **Delay / attrition**: stalled for years while legal and political battles proceed; financing and investor confidence erode; the proponent sometimes walks away.
- **Defeat**: the project proceeds. Focus then shifts to compliance monitoring, the next legal opening, and stewardship.

Why It's Worth It — Even If You Ultimately Lose

Be honest with your community about the odds — and equally honest about what the “secondary” outcomes are actually worth, because they are not consolation prizes:

- **Conditions and monitoring protect bodies for decades.** Buffers, emission controls, closure funds, independent monitoring with public data — these are measured in children's health and the water people actually drink, for the life of the project. Every binding condition you force is future harm partially averted.
- **Delay is real harm avoided — and real leverage.** Every year a project stalls is a year the land and the livelihoods run — and delay compounds against the proponent: financing costs, aging forecasts, expiring permits, changing governments. Some “delayed” projects simply never come back.
- **The organization outlives the fight.** The coalition, the trained monitors, the relationships with lawyers and journalists — that infrastructure fights the next application, the next route, the next permit renewal. Communities that fought “losing” battles are the ones that win the next one.
- **You change the rules for everyone.** Campaigns in this guide lost projects and won statutes, precedents, and reformed procedures the whole country then uses. Fighting at the level of one project builds law at the level of all of them.
- **You raise the price of the next project.** A proponent that spent years and a fortune on your fight prices community resistance into every future plan — and sometimes walks away before starting. Deterrence is invisible and real.
- **Compensation and dignity are not nothing.** Where harm proceeds, documented communities win remediation, compensation, and terms silent ones never see — and a community that fought knows itself differently afterward. Agency, once exercised, doesn't un-learn.

Decision Point: Continue, Modify, or Reassess

Continue if the legal challenge is on schedule, opposition is holding or growing, media is at least monthly, the coalition is stable, and the decision is more than three months out. **Modify** if attendance is declining, coverage has dropped for 2+ months, coalition members are leaving, the legal challenge has stalled, or you discover the system is more tilted than assessed. **Reassess** if, after ~12 months, legal and political options are exhausted, the decision appears settled despite real effort, the community is exhausted, or resources are depleted. In reassessment, ask: has opposition already won partial victory (modifications, delay)? Would continued effort win more, or just prolong the fight? Should energy shift to

monitoring compliance, to the next decision, or to broader systemic change?

The Bottom Line

Opposition work can stop or significantly modify destructive projects in Canada — even where parts of the system are tilted toward approval. Opposition creates multiple, compounding forms of pressure: legal, political, media, and community. Where the tilt is severe, an outright stop is less likely, but opposition still delivers delays, modifications, political costs, and durable power.

And Canadian law provides a powerful floor: constitutional protection for Indigenous rights that no legislature can remove. Time and again, determined communities — especially in respectful alliance with the nations whose rights the Constitution protects — have stopped what was supposed to be unstoppable.

Know your situation. Assess how tilted the system is, honestly. Choose your strategy accordingly. Then organize — with eyes open to both the possibilities and the barriers.

Nothing here is legal advice. The duty-to-consult and UNDRIP/DRIPA landscape is evolving quickly — get current advice from counsel or one of the charities above before relying on it.